



of layout, there's nothing much to complain about, and the Micro-ATX form factor means there's that much less room to play around with placements anyway.

We also received an MSI motherboard based on the GeForce 6150 chipset, which integrates a GeForce 6150 graphics controller onboard. For those who don't know, this chipset is a slightly stripped down GeForce 6200 core, which was the entry level chipset of NVIDIA's GeForce 6 series of graphics cards. With decent graphics performance for everyday applications, and the option to house the most powerful graphics cards via its PCI-Express slot, all audiences can be satisfied.

Performance

Our performance leaders were the duo from ASUS, their A8R32-MVP deluxe and the A8R-MVP. One of the reasons for this victory is the fact that the other 939 boards were onboard graphics solutions, which makes it mandatory for us to test them as such. These two boards were tested on a 7900GTX graphics card, which is at least 20 times more powerful than any onboard solution that has ever been around.

Nonetheless, the *Digit Best Buy Gold* award goes to the ASUS A8R-MVP, which manages to skim ahead of its bigger brother—the ASUS A8R32-MVP Deluxe—the winner of our *Digit Best Buy Silver* award.

MOTHERBOARDS FOR THE INTEL PLATFORM

We received for review a total of 17 boards that support Intel CPUs. Seven were from MSI, six from Gigabyte, and there were one each from ASUS, ASRock, ECS, and Intel.

In terms of chipsets, most support the older Pentium 4s and the latest Core 2 Duos as well. ATI, Intel, NVIDIA, VIA and SiS are some of the major chipset providers. However, all but two of the boards we tested were based on Intel chipsets (P965 Express, G965 Express, 975X Express, 945G Express and 945GZ Express)—the exception was the NVIDIA nForce 4 SLI chipset.

The older 945 chipset is almost at the end of

its life cycle, but since the Indian market is driven by value for money, you will still find a lot of cheaper boards using this chipset. Vendors are even providing BIOS revisions to enable the 945 series of motherboards to support Core 2 Duo. Even though nForce 4 SLI-based motherboards don't support the latest Core 2 Duo family, their prices are still very high compared to other motherboards. The 965s—designed for the Core 2 Duos CPU—are gradually trickling into the market, and it will take a while before they replace the 945s. With vendors already declaring support for Intel's upcoming quad-core CPUs, the 965s are your best bet for a future-proof solution. The 975X chipset, though designed for Pentium D CPUs, still support Core 2 Duos—thanks to BIOS revisions—and despite their age, are good performers.

All the chipsets featured RAID solutions, integrated by the chipset manufacturer. While Intel chipsets have their Matrix Storage solution, NVIDIA chipsets feature NV RAID, which will let you span your RAID set up across SATA and IDE drives.

In order to give you a clearer picture, we came up with three groups for all these motherboards: all boards based on the 975X and nForce 4 SLI chipset were grouped together because they have multi-GPU support. The 945G/GZ-based boards were grouped together, as they support Pentium D CPUs (with a few exceptions). The P965/G965-based motherboards were classified in the same group.

Intel P965 and G965 Features

We tested seven motherboards that were powered by the 965 chipset, from ASUS, Gigabyte, and MSI. Both the P965 Express and G965 Express chipsets made appearances. Both these support up to 1066 MHz FSB for Core 2 Duos. The major difference between them is that the G965 features onboard Intel Graphics Media

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